He was floating on it. And around him, his family was screaming, praising him, and their beaks were offering him scraps of dog-fish.

He had made his first flight.

About the author



Liam O'Flaherty (1896–1984) was an Irish novelist and short story writer and a major figure in the Irish literary renaissance. He was a founding member of the Communist Party of Ireland. A native Irish-speaker from the Gaeltacht, O'Flaherty wrote almost exclusively in English, except for a small number of short stories in the Irish language. He spent most of his time in travelling and lived comfortably and quietly outside the spotlight.

Glossary

ledge (n)- a narrow shelf that juts out from a vertical surface

shrilly (adv.)- producing a high-pitched and piercing voice or sound

herring (n)- a long silver fish that swims in large groups in the sea

devour (v)- to eat something eagerly and in large amounts, so that nothing is left

cackle (n)- a sharp, broken noise or cry of a hen, goose or seagull

mackerel (n)- a sea fish with a strong taste, often used as food

gnaw (v)- to bite or chew something repeatedly

trot (v)- to run at a moderate pace with short steps

precipice (n)- a very steep side of a cliff or a mountain

whet (v)- to sharpen

preening (v)- cleaning feathers with beak

plaintively (adv.)- sadly, calling in a sad way

swoop (v)- to move very quickly and easily through the air

beckoning (v)- making a gesture with the hand or head to encourage someone to approach or follow.

A. Answer the following questions in a sentence or two.

4BL5QL

1. How was the young seagull's first attempt to fly?
2. How did the parents support and encourage the young seagull's brothers and sister?
3. Give an instance that shows the pathetic condition of the young bird.
4. How did the bird try to reach its parents without having to fly?
5. Do you think that the young seagull's parents were harsh to him? Why?
6. What prompted the young seagull to fly finally?
7. What happened to the young seagull when it landed on the green sea?

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